



DURING THE NATIONWIDE lockdown in 2020, Prateek Bhardwaj—an MBA graduate from the small town of Garhmukteshwar in Hapur district of Uttar Pradesh—started making videos on Moj, a short-form video-sharing platform. His very first video went viral because of its relatable, family-driven comedy content and helped him gain 1 million followers in just 35 days. Back then, it was unthinkable in Bhardwaj's hometown that creating short-form videos could be a profession; fast forward to today and the 30-year-old content creator has 3.4 million followers on Moj and earns between ₹80-90 lakh a month.

Bhardwaj isn't alone. The Moj platform showcases videos from more than 50 million creators. In

fact, Moj, along with TakaTak and social media platform ShareChat (both owned by Moj's parent Mohalla Tech), have a total monthly active user (MAU) base of 400 million. India's short-form video space is on fire thanks to Indians' insatiable appetite for such videos. According to Meta, which corners a lion's share of the space with Reels on its photo-sharing platform Instagram, as many as 6 million Reels are produced daily on its platform for India.

Chinese short-video giant TikTok first introduced Indians to the format; but after it was banned in June 2020, other players saw a 1.37x surge in MAUs till the end of 2021, according to RedSeer, which tracks the space. "Post the ban, there was increasing interest among consum-

ers and it's fulfilling a certain need. There's a plethora of content out there but people have started paying more attention to the shorter formats," says Ajit Varghese, Chief Commercial Officer of ShareChat. One of the reasons for the rising popularity of short-form video, he adds, "is the shorter attention span of consumers over the last few decades". The second reason, he adds, is that short-form video apps provide the possibility of more fresh content.

But how does one stand out in a market where there are a dozen other such apps? For Varghese, it is by providing more personalised content at scale. "There will always be competition but the power of data will differentiate us," says Varghese, adding that the presence of many players in the space shows the heightened consumer interest. "The reason why you [a consumer] stick to a particular app is because it's highly personalised to your interest. Just because there are more players doesn't mean that all of them will survive."

Speaking of competition, Meta says that the meteoric rise of short-form video in India in the last two years has been led by Reels. "It is our aim to help the creator ecosystem realise the economic value of their community and fan franchises. We provide multiple models, products and programmes—be it funded programmes or initiatives that help enable creation and experimentation, acknowledging and rewarding performance, [and] connecting creators with economic opportunities like branded content," says Paras Sharma, Director and Head of Content & Community Partnerships-Entertainment, Sports, News, Music, Social, Facebook India (Meta).

The biggest challenge for short-